Look at Who Keeps Your Mother's Week Running While There's Time to Adjust

Four prompts to map an ordinary week of help, spot the assumptions holding it together, name a backup for the people who can't be replaced, and set aside the concerns that deserve a professional's eye.

Where you are

Your mother is doing fine at home, and the help around her has settled into a routine that works. Nobody has fallen, nothing has broken. You just haven't asked what happens if your brother takes that job out of state, or if the neighbor who checks in moves away.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can describe how your mother's week is held together, which pieces depend on one person, who could step in, and which small concerns you would rather raise now than later.

A one-page support map: Who helps and when, What we're assuming, Backup for each role, and Concerns worth raising now.

Before you start

- A sense of your mother's ordinary week: who comes by, who calls, who drives.
- Any routine tasks that one person always handles, like pills, bills, or groceries.
- A quiet half hour. That's really all this takes; you don't need paperwork.

PROMPT 1

Map an ordinary week of help

WHY THIS MATTERS

Routines become invisible. The help your mother gets probably works so smoothly that nobody has written it down, which is exactly why nobody can see where it's thin.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A rough account of who does what for your mother in a normal week.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother lives at home and manages well with some help from family and friends. Nothing is urgent. I want to see her ordinary week clearly. Here is what I know about who helps and when:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Lay this out as a weekly grid: days of the week across the top, and rows for MORNING, AFTERNOON, EVENING, and OVERNIGHT. In each cell, put who is with her or checking on her and what they do, using only what I wrote. Leave a cell blank if no one is there, rather than filling it in. Below the grid, list the tasks I mentioned that don't fit a time slot, like bills or pharmacy runs, with who does each.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The blank cells, and whether they bother you.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the grid to your mother and ask what you've missed.

PROMPT 2

Find the assumptions holding it together

WHY THIS MATTERS

Every arrangement rests on a few quiet assumptions: that your sister stays nearby, that the neighbor keeps checking in, that your mother keeps driving. Naming them isn't pessimism. It's the planning part of planning ahead.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The grid from the first prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the weekly map of help my mother receives:
>
> [PASTE THE GRID FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> For each person who appears, write one sentence beginning “This works as long as...” that states what we are counting on, such as their health, their job, where they live, or their own family demands. Then list the roles that would be hardest to replace if that person stepped away for a month. Finally, point out anything my mother does for herself that the whole week quietly

> depends on, like driving or managing her own medications. Describe these as dependencies to think about, not as risks or problems.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The “as long as” sentences you have never said out loud.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the one that worries you most and have a conversation with that person about their own plans.

PROMPT 3

Name a backup for each role

WHY THIS MATTERS

A backup doesn't have to be another relative. It can be a friend, a service you have looked into, or simply knowing who you would call. What matters is that the answer exists before you need it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The roles and dependencies from the second prompt, and a list of anyone else who might be willing to help.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> These are the roles in my mother's week and the people who fill them, plus a list of other people who might be able to help if asked:
>
> [PASTE THE ROLES FROM PROMPT 2 AND YOUR LIST OF POSSIBLE HELPERS]
>
> Make a table with columns: ROLE, WHO DOES IT NOW, WHO COULD COVER FOR A WEEK, WHO COULD COVER LONGER, and NOBODY IDENTIFIED YET. Use only the names I gave you. Don't suggest hiring anyone or name any kind of service or agency. Where the answer is NOBODY IDENTIFIED YET, write one question I could ask my family to start finding someone.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many roles land in the last column.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask one potential backup whether they would be willing, in principle, before anything is needed.

PROMPT 4

Set aside the concerns worth raising now

WHY THIS MATTERS

Small things you've noticed, a wobble on the stairs, pills in the wrong day of the box, a stove left on once, are easier to mention to a professional when nothing is urgent. Writing them down keeps them from being forgotten or inflated.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts, and any small concerns you have noticed or heard about.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the support map, assumptions, and backup list I've built for my mother, along with a few small things I've noticed or been told about:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3 AND YOUR CONCERNS]
>
> Give me a single page with four headings: WHO HELPS AND WHEN, WHAT WE'RE ASSUMING, BACKUP FOR EACH ROLE, and CONCERNS WORTH RAISING NOW. Under the last heading, write each concern as something specific I observed and a question I could ask her doctor, pharmacist, or a care consultant about it. Do not tell me whether any concern is serious, do not suggest changes to her home or medications, and do not say whether the current arrangement is safe.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that feels calm to read. If it reads like an alarm, go back and separate what you saw from what you feared.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put a date on it and set a reminder to revisit it in a year, or when anyone on the map has a change in their own life.

Make the map part of a fuller picture

Your support map is one piece of your mother's situation. The care interview puts it next to what she can do for herself, her health information, and her preferences, and keeps it all in one Family Care Profile the family can return to when something changes.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›